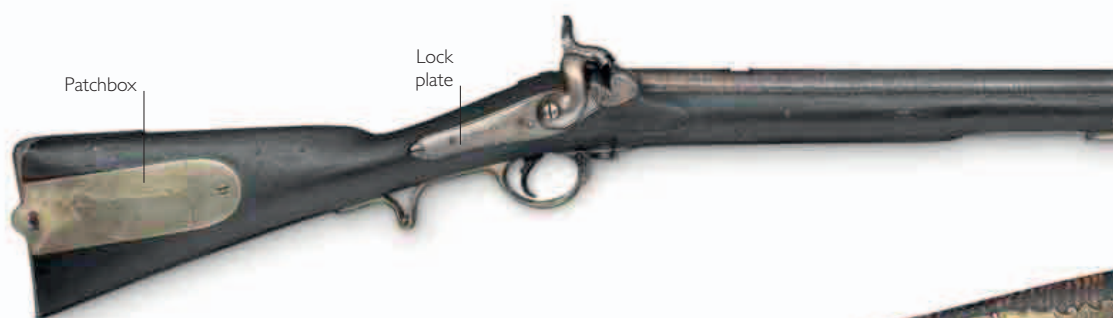


MUSKETS AND RIFLES (1831–52)

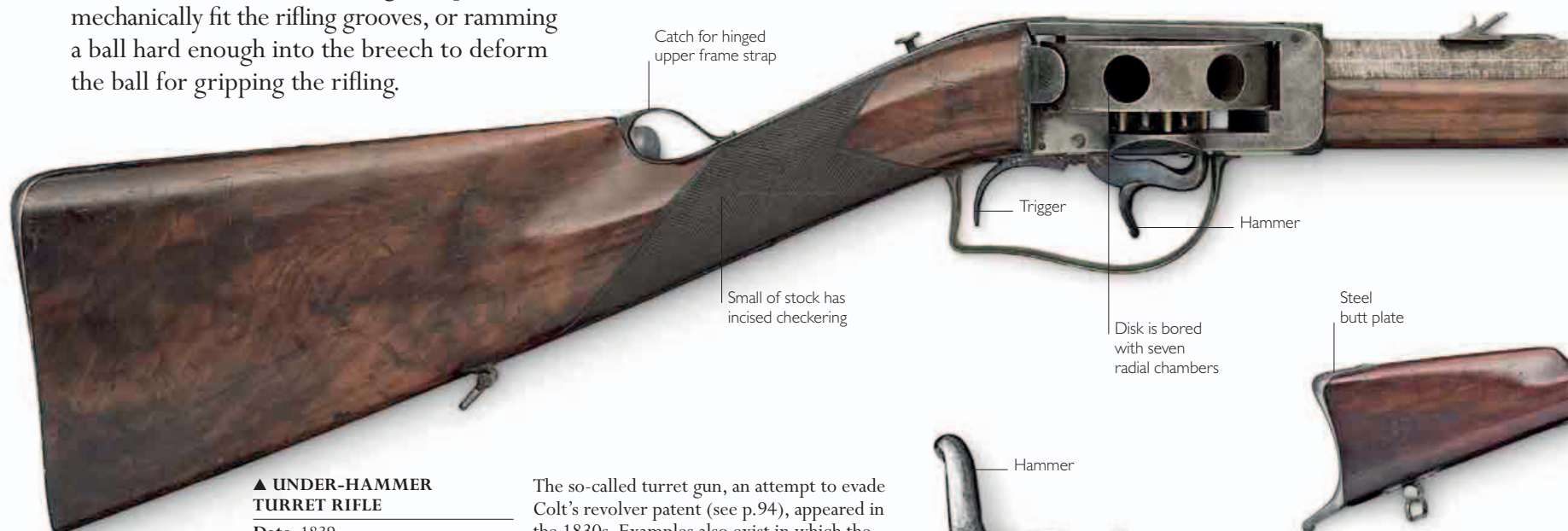
Many flintlock firearms remained in active use well into the 19th century. The iconic Kentucky long rifle was one of many civilian arms that saw sustained use as a flintlock, only gradually being converted to percussion ignition. European countries began to adopt rifles more widely for military use. Loading a rifle via the muzzle remained a problem. Rifles were loaded either using a shaped ball to mechanically fit the rifling grooves, or ramming a ball hard enough into the breech to deform the ball for gripping the rifling.



▲ BRUNSWICK RIFLE

Date c.1837
Origin UK
Barrel 32½in (82.5cm)
Caliber .71in (18.03mm)

This percussion-cap rifle was introduced into British military service in 1830. It had deep, two-groove rifling and fired a lead ball with an integral band, or belt, around it. This belt fit into the grooves and caused the ball to spin as it was fired (see pp.98–99).



▲ UNDER-HAMMER TURRET RIFLE

Date 1839
Origin UK
Barrel 29in (73.7cm)
Caliber .69in (17.6mm)

The so-called turret gun, an attempt to evade Colt's revolver patent (see p.94), appeared in the 1830s. Examples also exist in which the wheel of cylinders is set vertically. It soon became apparent that if flash-over from one cylinder to another occurred, the result would most likely be catastrophic to any bystanders, or even to the shooter himself.

